



magazine

backpage
Bengaluru maps 1,500 years of Indian ‘comics’

GO TO » PAGE 8

INSIDE
The overlooked masters of Raja Ravi Varma’s era

GO TO » PAGE 4

LITERARY REVIEW
Why Mohsin Khan’s new novel is essential reading

GO TO » PAGE 2

Track the latest stories via #ThMagazine on Instagram and X (formerly Twitter) Get connected » www.thehindu.com

HOW LADAKH LANDED ON THE CHEESE MAP

Thenlay Nurboo never left Changthang, but his cheese did — and won a gold in Brazil. The award is now inspiring him to fight for yak herding

Rinchen Angmo Chumikchan

It is 1°C in the highland pastures of Ladakh’s Changthang region, and first light is just breaking as Thenlay Nurboo bundles up in a thick yak wool sweater and

steps out of his tent. At 5.30 every morning, the 36-year-old begins milking his family’s shaggy-haired yak herd grazing at 16,600 feet. The task is slow — taking around four to five hours — and entirely manual.

His family owns around 100 yaks, of which 50 to 60 are

milked each day, yielding nearly 60 litres of milk. Each yak, Nurboo says, produces 1 to 1.5 litres. For generations, this rich milk, with its distinct earthy aroma and creamy notes, has been turned into butter, buttermilk and cheese — food essential for survival in the

high-altitude landscape of Ladakh. But this April, Nurboo’s *chhurpe* travelled much farther than Changthang, to win a gold medal at the fourth edition of the Mundial do Queijo do Brasil, a biennial international competition for cheese and dairy products. He, however, was not there to receive it.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGES 4-5



A yak in Tso Kar, in Ladakh’s Changthang region. (GETTY IMAGES/ ISTOCK)



ELITE MATRIMONY

Where India's Finest Families Meet.
Pioneering Elite Matchmaking Since 2008.

From
Matrimony.com
Group

ELITE BRIDES WANTED

BRAHMIN NIYOGLI, 32, 178 cms, Legal Professional. Master's degree in the USA. Lives in Delhi. Parents are IAS officials. Family affluent. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match from the same community, who can relocate to Delhi. Contact: 6366448344

BRAHMIN, 28, 165 cms, Businessman. MBA degree. Lives in Trichy. Family is financially well off. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match from the same community, who can relocate to Trichy. Contact: 6366448344

CHETTIAR, 28, 191 cms, Entrepreneur. BBA. Lives in Chennai. Family is financially well off with a good net worth. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match from same or similar community. Contact: 6366448344

CHETTIAR, 27, 168 cms, Entrepreneur. B.Arch. Lives in Coimbatore. Family is financially well off with a good net worth. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match from similar community, from Kongu region. Contact: 6366448344

INTERCASTE, 30, 173 cms, Entrepreneur. MBA degree. Lives in Chennai. Family is financially well off. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match from similar community in Chennai. Contact: 6366448344

BANIYA, 33, 155 cms, Management Professional. Double Master's degree. Lives in Singapore. Family is financially well off. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match from similar community, abroad. Contact: 6366448344

ELITE GROOMS WANTED

MUDALIYAR, 31, 160 cms, Entrepreneur. MBA degree. Lives in Tiruppur. Family is financially well off with a good net worth. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match from the same community. Contact: 6366448343

PILLAI, 24, 160 cms, Doctor. Pursuing MD Paediatrics. Family is financially well off with a good net worth. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match from similar community, from Tamil Nadu. Contact: 6366448343

PILLAI, 28, 168 cms, Legal Professional. LL.M. Lives in Chennai. Family is financially well off. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match from the same community, in Chennai. Contact: 6366448343

REDDY, 29, 173 cms, Entrepreneur. MBA degree. Lives in Chennai. Family is financially well off with a good net worth. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match from the same or similar community. Contact: 6366448343

LOHANA, 39, 155 cms, Entrepreneur. BA (Hons). Lives in Mozambique. Family is financially well off. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match from the same community, from the USA or India. Contact: 6366448343

ADI DRAVIDA, 26, 152 cms, HR professional. MA (HRM). HR. Lives in Chennai. Family is financially well off with a good net worth. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match from the same community. Contact: 6366448343

THE ELITE PROMISE

1 Lakh+
Elite Families
Served

Dedicated
Relationship
Managers

Guaranteed Matches
Assured Meetings

18+ Years of Elite
Matchmaking
Experience

Personalised
& Confidential
Service

Schedule a Confidential Call 99629 76000 www.elitematrimony.com

WOMEN IN TRANSLATION MONTH

Hear me roar

Presenting verse as emancipation, the poets in this anthology assert their right to speak, and to be heard

Chintan Girish Modi

One of the best ways to learn about a sociopolitical movement is to immerse yourself in the poetry it has produced. Across centuries and geographies, poetry has been used by oppressed communities both as balm and weapon. For them, a poem is not merely a vehicle to deliver a message; seeing it as such is a grave mistake. It is an emotional creature, seething with rage or brimming with hope, plotting revenge with a glint in the eye or envisioning a brave new world.

Leaping Towards the Deep Blue Sky, edited and illustrated by Shrujana N. Shridhar, is an anthology of poems “articulating an embodied experience of Dalit womanhood: resisting Brahmanical patriarchy, building resilient communities, standing firmly in anti-caste conviction, dreaming of autonomy, and lastly, finding freedom in the process”. The poems, originally written in Marathi, have been translated into English by the editor, along with Shreeja Rao.

B.R. Ambedkar’s clarion call ‘Educate, Agitate, Organise’ is the beating heart of this volume brought out by Maveli Publications, an anti-caste publishing platform championing Dalit voices.

The Dalit womanhood
In the poem ‘Bhima’s Pen’, for instance, Hira Bansode, one of the pioneers of Dalit feminist poetry in Marathi, declares: *I am the blazing waters of Mahad/ I will show every woman/ How the cruel Manusmriti, like a venomous serpent/ Has been sinking its fangs into her life since birth/ Poisoning her existence*. This poem is not a plea; it is a roar. And the imagery is drawn out of the collective memory of a community that has used non-violent means to fight back. It refers to the Mahad Satyagraha of 1927, launched to demand access to water regardless of caste. In ‘Warrior Woman’, Sharda Navale, a teacher

with the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation, pays homage to social reformer Savitribai Phule, who *unlocked the treasure trove of knowledge and shattered the impregnable bastions of sanatana*. She is the guiding light to emulate when one is overwhelmed by injustice and discrimination.

Another teacher, Varsha Bhise, writes *Their god felt desecrated/ when we entered the temple/ So we embraced Buddha* in her poem ‘What Was Our Crime...?’ The structural violence is named but from a position of agency rather than helplessness. She

that “Our men suffer just like us”, realised that Dalit men too benefited from patriarchy, and their creative expression began to reflect this awareness. “Around 1990, a distinct articulation of Dalit feminism began to emerge,” she notes. Since men dominated the Ambedkarite movement, and “upper-caste” women monopolised the feminist movement, Dalit women felt compelled to carve out a space for themselves to speak and share.

Question of faith

Chhaya Koregaonkar, a retired bank officer, writes about women who *soothe bruises on their backs left by in-laws with turmeric paste* in her poem ‘Women’. Even Buddhism, which offered the promise of equality and dignity to Ambedkar and his followers, is examined with a critical gaze. In another poem titled ‘It’s Not Easy’, Koregaonkar points out that Yashodhara, who married Prince Siddhartha – the man who went on to become the Buddha – *has no place in any Buddha Vihara*. Faith does not preclude questioning.

Shital Sathe, co-founder of Navayan Mahajalsa and Kalasangini, who was seen in Anand Patwardhan’s documentary film *Jai Bhim Comrade* (2011), offers a scathing critique of artists who *sing praises of the master/ to be decorated by the hands of the President*. For her, as for many others featured in this book, the purpose of poetry is emancipation, not adornment.

Pradnya Pawar, Disha Pinki Shaikh, Sneha Kadam, Ushakiran Atram, Sandhya Tambe, Surekha Bhagat and Rajyashri Goody are the other poets featured in *Leaping Towards the Deep Blue Sky*. This anthology would make a valuable addition to courses in literature, gender studies, translation, and postcolonial writing at colleges and universities in India and abroad.

The literary critic’s poems have appeared in Fearless Love and Bent Book.



Leaping Towards the Deep Blue Sky
Ed. & trs Shrujana N. Shridhar,
trs Shreeja Rao
Maveli Publications
₹249

adds, *Their religion of torment/ never felt like ours/ So we found solace in Dhamma*. The ability to imagine and find an alternative is attributed to Ambedkar here: *When we had no one, Bhim became our father*.

Writer-activist Urmila Pawar’s erudite foreword situates this collection within the broader history of the Ambedkarite movement, tracing the evolution of Dalit literature and the conception of a Dalit feminist identity. “While Dalit literature is generally considered to have begun around the 1960s, a distinct shift occurred with the establishment of the Dalit Panther movement in 1972,” she notes. Dalit women, who once believed



A new dawn A Women’s Day celebration at Ambedkar Bhawan in New Delhi. (ANI)



Young boys praying at Jama Masjid in Agra. (GETTY IMAGES)

ANTIDOTE FOR THE TIMES

A master storyteller, Mohsin Khan draws readers in through skilful and satisfying foreshadowing

Amitabha Bagchi

Gibran, the protagonist of *Allah Miyan’s Workshop* by Mohsin Khan, lives in a small village somewhere in North India with his gentle-hearted sister Nusrat, his ever-suffering mother, and his orthodox father who not only wants his children to live a life solely focused on prayer and religious observance but also volunteers to go preaching around the country with the Tablighi Jamaat for days on end, telling his wife that if she runs out of money, “Allah will provide”.

Unlike the well-loved and soft-hearted Hamid in Premchand’s short story ‘Idgah’, Gibran is a self-involved child whose primary purpose in life is to organise money, by means fair or foul, to buy himself a kite. He is at odds with the better-off Ahmad who destroys his kite and refuses to replace it; with Ram Sewak (the only Hindu character in the book) whose quarrel with him over a minor matter quickly takes on communal proportions; and with his madrasa teacher Hafiji who is often forced to take the Cane of Edification to his backside.

It is only after the book ends that the reader realises that although Gibran doesn’t redeem himself with word or deed till near the end of the book, we still care for him, deeply, for the same reason that he cares for Kallo, his beloved hen that the cat takes: because he is innocent.

Grounded in Islam
Allah Miyan’s Workshop, translated from the Urdu by

Maaz Bin Bilal, is clearly the work of a master of the short story, a wonderfully smooth narrative unfurling, a self-contained tale that keeps drawing the reader forward into heartbreak with subtle and not-so-subtle, but always pleasing, forms of foreshadowing.

There are several turns in the narrative but their pleasure cannot be destroyed by giving spoilers in this review. Let me just say that after the hen Kallo gets killed by the cat, Gibran asks his sister, “When Allah Miyan made the hen, why did He make the cat?”, and this question captures the pathos of the world of the novel, of Gibran’s world as it unravels, and indeed of the world we all live in.

The tension between orthodox Muslims and Muslims who want to make their way in the secular world is vividly portrayed in the

Indian readers of this book, Muslim and non-Muslim, will likely find many things in here that they don’t know, or thought they knew but didn’t know the way this novel seems to know them. And they will feel discomfort

book, as is the stress created within the community by the unrelenting suspicion of a harsh state.

But to view this book as just a footnote to the news items we have become inured to reading would be a mistake. Written in simple language in the original Urdu, and rendered in equally straight English, this book doesn’t just demonstrate how Islam structures the life of the people in Gibran’s world, it actually reproduces that structure through a variety of references.

A kite hanging from a tree outside Gibran’s madrasa happens to be green in colour with a crescent and a star on it. Gibran’s uncle’s dog is named Qitmīr after the famous dog who, in a Quranic story, protects seven sleeping believers from being targeted by their enemies. Hafiji’s goat is named Yamin after the Prophet’s goat. As the book makes its way to its end, we begin to see how the narrative’s movement itself and the epigrams that appear at frequent intervals appear to be giving a kind of lesson that is grounded in Islamic thought.

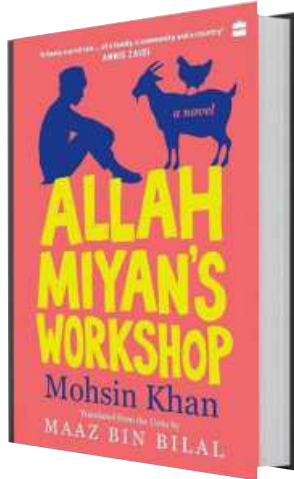
Even for a non-Muslim reader, it isn’t hard to see that the novel is looking to teach Muslims – and non-Muslims – something. It comes as no surprise to learn that Khan has written extensively for children as well.

Both rose and thorn
“Write about what you know” was the advice Ismat Chughtai, who mentored Khan early in his career, gave him. Undoubtedly, *Allah Miyan’s Workshop* can be read within the genealogy of short fiction in Urdu and Hindi that appeared in periodicals in the 20th century, and which considered a deep immersion into the geographically and culturally rooted life of the common man, a sine qua non of its existence.

As such, Indian readers of this book in English, Muslim and non-Muslim, will likely find many things in here that they don’t know, or thought they knew but didn’t know the way this novel seems to know them. And they will feel discomfort. Because *Allah Miyan’s Workshop* is a book that makes life bearable and unbearable at the same time, it is rose and thorn fused into one.

Those of us alive today have all seen things no human, child or adult, should have had to see. And we have all asked ourselves: how do we live in this cruel world? For the religious who follow Islam, the novel suggests the prayer for safety: “I seek refuge in the perfect words of Allah from the evil of what He has created.” For the rest of us, I recommend *Allah Miyan’s Workshop*.

The reviewer’s most recent novel is Unknown City.

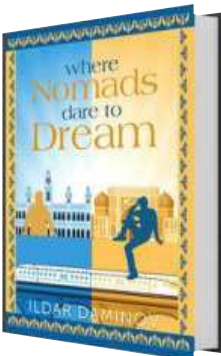


Allah Miyan’s Workshop
Mohsin Khan,
trs Maaz Bin Bilal
Harper Perennial
₹499

BROWSER

Where Nomads Dare to Dream

Ildar Daminov
NineStar Press
₹2,016
In this coming-of-age novel set in Vienna, a young gay man from a small Central Asian town discovers a world and a life far bigger than he imagined. The story celebrates resilience, hope, and the courage to embrace one’s true self.



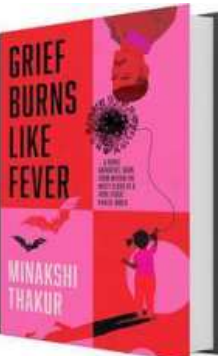
Cool Machine

Colson Whitehead
Hachette India
₹799
The Pulitzer Prize-winning author brings his *Harlem Trilogy* to a close with a gripping crime saga set against the transformation of 1980s New York. Known for his richly layered storytelling, Whitehead explores race, power and the enduring complexities of the American experience.



Grief Burns Like Fever

Minakshi Thakur
Tranquebar
₹499
Revisiting the devastating second wave of the COVID-19 pandemic, the author tells the story through the eyes of a Delhi ambulance driver and other ordinary people as they try to make sense of the chaos around them.



More Days at the Torunka Cafe

Satoshi Yagisawa
Bonnier Books UK
₹499
The Japanese author returns to the cosy Torunka Cafe with three interconnected stories of love, memory and second chances. Yagisawa is among a new wave of writers popularising ‘healing fiction’ that focuses on ordinary moments, hope and human connection.



Secret histories of India's trees

T.R. Shankar Raman's book reads like a set of vivid short stories rather than a dry botanical account



Illustrations from the book.

Divya Gandhi
divya.gandhi@thehindu.co.in

There is a conspicuous white blotch in the vague shape of a tree in one of the spectacular illustrations in *The Trees of My Country: A Natural History of India in 50 Trees* by wildlife scientist T.R. Shankar Raman. The page, illustrated by Manali Patil, who had to work with scant botanical evidence and vivid imagination, opens onto a bay in the Great Nicobar Island. There is a stem with pointed leaves, a sea of ferns, and then an unpainted corner where a tree ought to have been.

This is – or perhaps was – the *Nicobariodendron sleumeri*, which Raman deduced from sparse archives. It grows on densely forested hilltops in the Nicobar, is about 30 metres high, with white fragrant flowers, conical red fruits, and glossy green leaves. It has eluded a systematic botanical study, but “it is... likely, that the Shompen and the Nicobarese [tribal communities] know the tree, have a name for it [and] use it for different purposes,” he writes.

Raman has, unsurprisingly, never seen the tree, and fears that before anyone does, “it may vanish off the face of the earth” with a “final death-blow” struck by the much-critiqued ₹81,800-crore proposed infrastructure project that involves the felling of hundreds of thousands of trees in the Great Nicobar.

Living with storytellers
The book explores in detail 50 native tree species across India, celebrating both the mundane and the threatened, the common and the rare, the urban and the wild, and the relationship of these trees with the landscapes they inhabit and the people who know and use them for their livelihood.

This work joins a formidable library of books on Indian trees, including Pradip Kishen's *Trees of Delhi*; Harini Nagendra and Seema Mundoli's *Cities and Canopies*; and S. Natesh's *Iconic Trees of India*.

My house, in the boondocks of Bengaluru, is canopied by a large *Albizia procera*, commonly known as karo. The tree is not just a bunch of branches and leaves; it is a thriving, ever-morphing world. I see mynahs building a nest in one of its hollows, stuffing it with feathers and leaves and the odd polythene bag. A yellow rat snake lives in the undergrowth beneath and tries

routinely, and unsuccessfully, to slither up the trunk to get at the birds' hatchlings. Ever so often there is a loud tussle between the birds and the reptile. At night, the base of the trunk is dappled by the dance of fireflies. And an invisible owl on a branch calls from its hidden perch. As Raman writes, “Every tree is a storyteller, a historian, a chronicler of place.”

While he was finishing the manuscript, the “irreligious” scientist found himself in Bodh Gaya one September. “Truth is, I'm not here for the Buddha at all, but for the tree, the Bodhi-druma,” he writes. It is believed to be a direct descendant of the tree under which Gautama is said to have attained enlightenment. The peepal “sprawls like a hemisphere”, where parakeets screech and pilgrims hum chants. He sat cross-legged among devotees on the ground, his thoughts entirely on the trees around him.

An enduring bond
Raman talks of the equation between trees and humanity. Living trees are livelihoods. In the chapter on the *Salix* willows of militarised Kashmir, the land of razor wires and armed

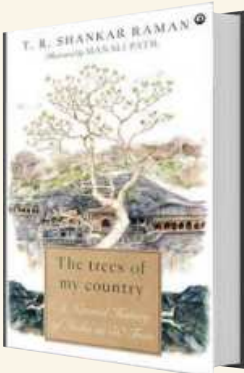
outposts, the botanical festoon “gird[s] paddy fields in [the] Valley, dot the periphery of the cultivated terraces or karewas on elevated plateaux, and line the banks of creeks and rivers”.

People have cultivated these willows, which are used for fodder and fashioned into baskets woven around charcoal fire pots. There is also the alien white willow, used to make cricket bats, making Kashmir the main centre of the country's bat-making industry. “Under a long, shameful shadow of unreconciled hostility between nations, India-Pakistan cricket

matches now signify war against enemies rather than sport between rivals,” says Raman, who writes about how the tree represents the “irony of a false nationalism”.

He confesses that the plurality of names assigned to each tree by India's many cultures posed a conundrum. The common name of one tree in the local language eluded Raman: the Nicobar bittersweet, which the Shompen and Great Nicobarese likely have their own name for.

The book is meticulously researched, with each chapter reading like a vivid story rather than a botanical account. It could, however, have done with an index in place of the alphabetically ordered enumeration of species mentioned in the text.



The Trees of My Country: A Natural History of India in 50 Trees
T.R. Shankar Raman; illustrated by Manali Patil
Aleph Book Company
₹1,499



THE LANGUAGE OF LEAVES

Sumana Roy's translation reveals the audacity – and the limits – of Jagadish Chandra Bose's scientific vision

Jacob Koshy
jacob.koshy@thehindu.co.in

Jagadish Chandra Bose struck a plant with a cane and then, with a watch in hand, waited for it to forgive him. Growth stalled, then resumed half an hour later. From this small cruelty he drew a large lesson – that injury stunts the sapling as surely as it stunts the schoolboy hit by a cane-wielding headmaster, and that the plant, like the boy hauled up by the ears, keeps account of what is done to it.

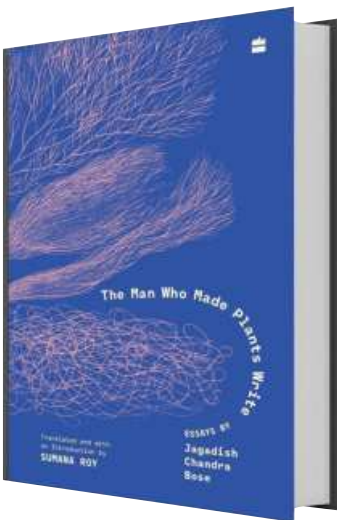
The essays in *The Man Who Made Plants Write* are full of such scenes: a Bengali physicist-turned-physiologist, hunched over instruments of his own devising, coaxing a mute organism into testimony.

Grand ambition
Sumana Roy's translation of *Abyakta* – “the unmanifest,” “the unsaid” – which Bose published in Bengali in 1922, introduces English-language readers to a Calcutta scientist who wrote for children. That readership is the point. Bose wrote these pieces in his mother tongue, Bangla, for a broad public and largely for the young, even though the scientific priesthood in England was split over the evidence that he proffered for the emotive life of plants.

What he was after was a unifying theory. Isaac Newton married the falling apple to the orbiting moon; James Clerk Maxwell folded light into electromagnetism; John Dalton weighed the atom; and Charles Darwin ran a single thread of descent through everything that lives. Bose's ambition belonged to that family. He wanted to abolish the border between the living and the

non-living, to show that metal fatigues and recovers like muscle, that a plant startles, tires, and swoons under chloroform. It was audacious and, in its literal form, wrong. But it was not mysticism in a lab coat. It was the era's most exciting physics pressed into the service of a real hypothesis: that the unseen exerts measurable effects, and that response might be the signature of life wherever it is found.

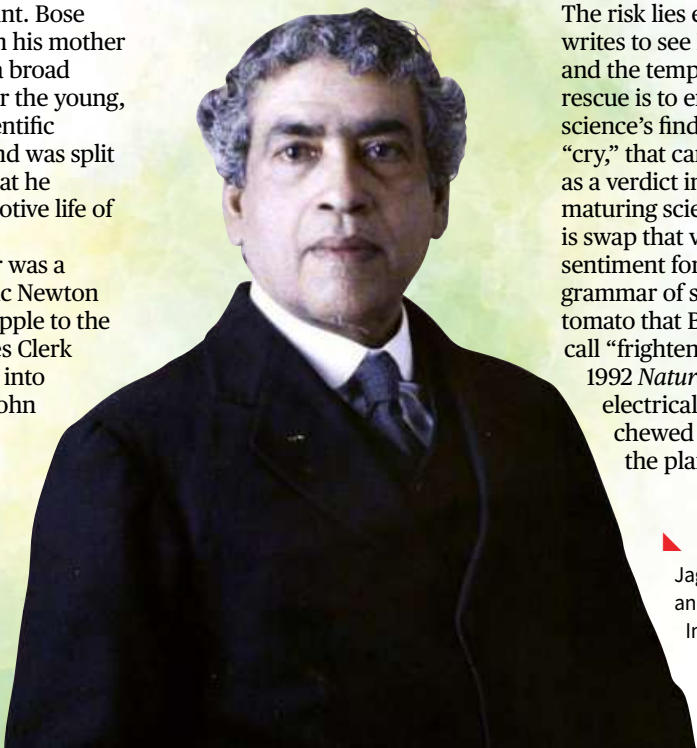
Roy's introduction is the finest thing in the volume. She ventured the translation to rescue the legacy of Bose, whose work with plants earned him mocking cartoons, a decade-long refusal by the Royal Society to publish him, and pledges by American laboratories to shield the public from “infantile fancies,” as one director branded Bose. She also reads Bose through the lens of her own childlessness, in kinship with a man who called seeds “a plant's children” and mothered his ferns for want of offspring of his own. It is a risky hinge – the personal threatening to overrun the scholarly – but her prose is too exact to tip into sentiment. She



The Man Who Made Plants Write: Essays by Jagadish Chandra Bose
Trs Sumana Roy
HarperCollins
₹599

catches what a botanist would probably miss: that Bose's records of stimulus are really a “First Information Report” of hurt, and that love – a word one never meets in a scientific tract – was his declared method.

A changed vocabulary
The risk lies elsewhere. Roy writes to see Bose vindicated, and the temptation of every such rescue is to enlist contemporary science's findings – plants that “cry,” that can be anaesthetised – as a verdict in his favour. What maturing science has done since is swap that vocabulary of sentiment for the plainer grammar of signalling. The tomato that Bose's heirs would call “frightened” turns out, in a 1992 *Nature* study, to relay an electrical pulse from a chewed leaf to the rest of the plant, which then



Jagadish Chandra Bose; and (top) the A.J.C. Bose Indian Botanical Garden in Kolkata.
(GETTY IMAGES)

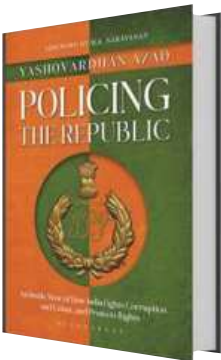
manufactures chemicals to see off the caterpillar – a defence circuit, not distress. “Crying” plants emit ultrasonic clicks under stress, not sobs. The field has even demoted itself: the Society for Plant Neurobiology, accused of smuggling a nervous system into the flowerbed, renamed itself the Society for Plant Signalling and Behaviour. Interconnectedness explains in several instances what Victorian science ascribed to human-like intelligence alone.

Bose was no denied genius nursing a grievance. He declined to patent his early radio-wave detector, or the coherer – ideas, he held, should be shared freely – and left to Guglielmo Marconi the commercial glory of wireless without ever waging the priority war that a nationalist school in India still fights on his behalf. His real bequest was a method: that the discovery of nature need not wait on costly infrastructure. His only collaborator was a tinsmith, Putiram Das. His crescograph was little more than needles, clockwork, and smoked glass. From that ethic descends a lineage of Indian science done with string and ingenuity – C.V. Raman splitting light on a shoestring, the cosmic-ray work of Meghnad Saha, Vikram Sarabhai, and Homi Bhabha – before the republic turned to Big Science and reactors.

One of the essays in the collection has Bose telling the story of David Schwarz's all-metal airship – mocked by the examiners as too heavy to ever leave the ground; of Samuel Langley, who died broken-hearted after his machine fell into the river; and of a Wright brother, who broke his leg mid-flight and simply began again until man could “extend his empire into the blue sky”. The metal balloon is the emblem: the seemingly inert, too-heavy, ridiculed thing, made to rise. This is a parable of daring – that the brave transcend the fear of failure and death. It is Bose defending, by analogy, his own unfashionable pursuit.

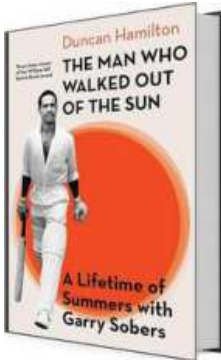
Policing the Republic
Yashovardhan Azad
Bloomsbury Publishing
₹699

Azad spent over four decades at the heart of India's law enforcement and intelligence establishment. The book examines policing, corruption, criminalisation of politics, terrorism, insurgency, intelligence operations, governance and national security.



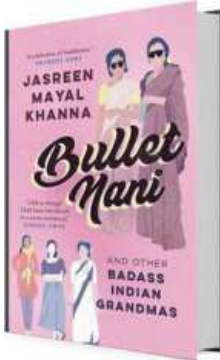
The Man Who Walked Out of the Sun
Duncan Hamilton
Abacus/Hachette
₹2,399

The book explores Hamilton's love for Garry Sobers, who personified the greatest of West Indian cricket. It combines personal remembrance with a study of Sobers' career and rise as the world's first “jet age” cricketer.



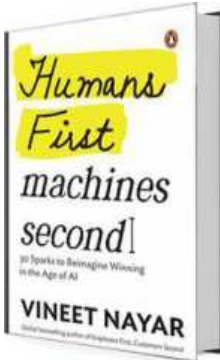
Bullet Nani and Other Badass Indian Grandmas
Jasreen Mayal Khanna
Pan Macmillan India
₹399

Drawing inspiration from her grandmother, Khanna tells the stories of 12 women who, in the face of entrenched patriarchy, laid the seeds for future generations to live their lives on their own terms.



Humans First, Machines Second
Vineet Nayar
Penguin
₹799

Through 30 stories based on lessons from boardrooms, classrooms, and crises, Nayar reveals a different path to winning in the age of AI. This is a guide for anyone who wants to remain human in a world being redesigned by AI.



CONTINUED FROM
» PAGE 1

Nurboo shares that he received the invitation only 12 days before the event, and needed a yellow fever vaccination before he could travel. He went to Delhi for the shot, only to reach the centre half an hour after it had closed. Eventually, he arranged for the cheese, a softer variant of the region's well-known *chhurpe*, to be taken to Brazil while he stayed back. "I did not want to waste government money," he explains. "I had already briefed the officials [of the National Dairy Development Board through whom he sent his product to the competition] about the process and told them to present the cheese."

Then came the unexpected news: the cheese – with its dense yet chewy texture and smoky flavour – that he had been making the same way his elders had for generations, had won gold.

For him, the award was more than just recognition for a food product. It helped settle a question he had been asking himself for years: was yak herding the right career choice? "Winning the award removed that doubt," says Nurboo, who has been herding yaks with his parents for seven years and, like many young people in Ladakh, has seen tourism and other professions as offering more opportunities. In many Changthang families, in fact, children are asked to herd yaks as punishment (because of its arduous nature) for not studying hard enough. "Winning made me certain that this is what I want to do; I don't have to pursue anything else," he adds.



The making of *chhurpe*

Chhurpe begins with fresh milk. It is heated to around 32°-35°C, depending on the weather. A few drops of culture is added, and the milk is allowed to ferment overnight. The following morning, it is churned for an hour. Traditionally, this was done using a *skyalpa*, a churn made from goat or sheep skin. Today, Nurboo uses a machine capable of churning 60 litres an hour.

Once the butter and *lassi* are separated, the butter is sold or made into ghee, while the *lassi* is boiled to produce cheese, which resembles ricotta when fresh. "It is drained for three to four hours, dried [pictured above] and made into a dough," says Nurboo. "Weather plays a critical role. In summer, when the yaks graze on fresh grass, the butter and cheese are richer, more yellow and flavourful. In winter, when grass is scarce, they are lighter in colour and contain less fat."

Meanwhile, the Animal Husbandry Department has helped Nurboo refine production standards to meet international hygiene and quality benchmarks. "Earlier, the cheese was dried on parachute cloth, leaving it exposed to dust and birds," he says. "The department has now provided cheese-drying shelves that allow it to dry faster and more cleanly." The final products include hard dried *chhurpe*, powdered cheese and a sweet cheese that Nurboo has recently introduced (which is sweetened with sugar before drying). The cheeses can be stored for up to two years.



HOW LADAKH LANDED ON THE CHEESE MAP

Understanding the product

At Nomadic Farm, his roadside artisanal enterprise in eastern Ladakh, the award and a letter of appreciation from President Droupadi Murmu are displayed prominently. Here, the yak cheese sells for ₹2,000 per kilo. Its distinctive character comes from the traditional way it is made, and the yaks' natural diet. "A large proportion of what the animals eat are

medicinal plants across the Himalayan region," says Nurboo, adding that the judges also appreciated the cheese's smoky flavour, which comes from using yak dung as fuel during cheesemaking. "I have not formally studied cheesemaking, but I have tried making cheeses like [French] Tomme and [Spanish] Manchego. We cannot compete with European cheeses because

they require large quantities of milk. So, we will continue to follow our traditional practices."

The recognition has meant that demand for yak milk, *lassi*, cheese and butter has increased in the last four months, and more locals and tourists are dropping by to learn about the products. "I tell them the story behind the cheese, about the yak herds

and the altitudes at which they graze," says Nurboo, who has been receiving queries from restaurants in cities like Mumbai. But, for the moment, he wants to stay small and artisanal. "Supplying to restaurants means I have to produce cheese in large quantities. For that, I'll need a large herd of more than 300 yaks, and enough pasture land for them, which isn't feasible.



(Clockwise from left) Nurboo drying *chhurpe*; yaks in Changthang; a nomadic camp; and Nurboo milking his yaks in the early hours of the morning. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

So, exports and large orders to hotels are not possible."

But the interest is encouraging Nurboo to understand his cheese better. For instance, he now knows that yak cheese is particularly rich in protein. "After extracting the cheese, the

residue, known as *churku*, is also high in protein. I am planning to make protein drinks from it," he says.

Local food to tasting menus

Nurboo is very aware of the paradox of his success. A cheese whose origin story is rooted in survival, made by a community that needed a way to preserve milk to last through their brutal winters, is now being celebrated as a luxury – with people discussing its tasting notes like they would Gruyère cheese's caramel complexity or Iberian ham's acorn-fed flavour. The question is: will its indigenous nature survive untouched?

"*Chhurpe* has always been a part of Himalayan kitchens. But to attain a wider audience, cheesemakers may either have to adopt western techniques or evolve traditional methods into something that has international appeal," says Shalini Philip, co-founder of The Farm, an integrated dairy farm and restaurant in Chennai, and a pioneer in India's artisanal cheese movement. "Once it is on



India made a successful debut at Mundial do Queijo do Brasil. Nurboo's Yak Churpi-Soft was one among four Indian cheeses that won. The others were from the artisanal brand Eleftheria: Gulmarg (super gold), Brunost (gold), and Kaali Miri (silver).



There have the yaks gone? Ironically, the award comes at a time when yak herding is

facing multiple challenges. Yaks are raised at altitudes between 13,000 and 17,000 feet. Climate change is altering the landscape on which the animals depend. Glaciers are retreating and snowfall has declined. "Earlier, we used to receive a lot of snow, but now there is more rain," Nurboo says. While this has led to greener mountain slopes, in the long run, if snowfall declines further, freshwater springs could dry up.

Yak rearing has also reportedly declined by nearly 50% across the Changthang region. Better employment opportunities are taking youngsters away from traditional careers. In fact, Nurboo's family is the only one selling yak milk in their village.

Add to this the economics of yak herding. Yak wool has little commercial value. While pashmina, Ladakh's most prized product, may fetch ₹6,000 to ₹8,000 a kilo, yak wool sells for only around ₹600 and has few buyers despite its potential. The wool can be used for blankets, shawls and sweaters, and to make *chhal* or mats. The traditional *rebo* tent, a staple of the pastoral nomads made from woven yak wool, is waterproof and can last up to 15 years. "The quality and potential are there, the question is why are we not making better use of them," asks Nurboo.

He is part of a 13-member Yak Herders Association formed five years ago to promote yak-based dairy products and improve the livelihoods of herders. They are advocating for the legalisation of yak meat too, which could potentially double farmers' incomes, they

believe. The Association is also asking for a National Research Centre for Yak to aid in the development of yak husbandry and related products.

The award could help change things for Changthang. "Now, young people may see the potential in dairy farming," says Konchok Norgay, a local entrepreneur. "Today, people are health conscious, and there is a huge demand for fresh, quality products. I see a lot of scope in the dairy sector, and I believe many more youngsters will take it up in the future."

Sustainable livelihoods

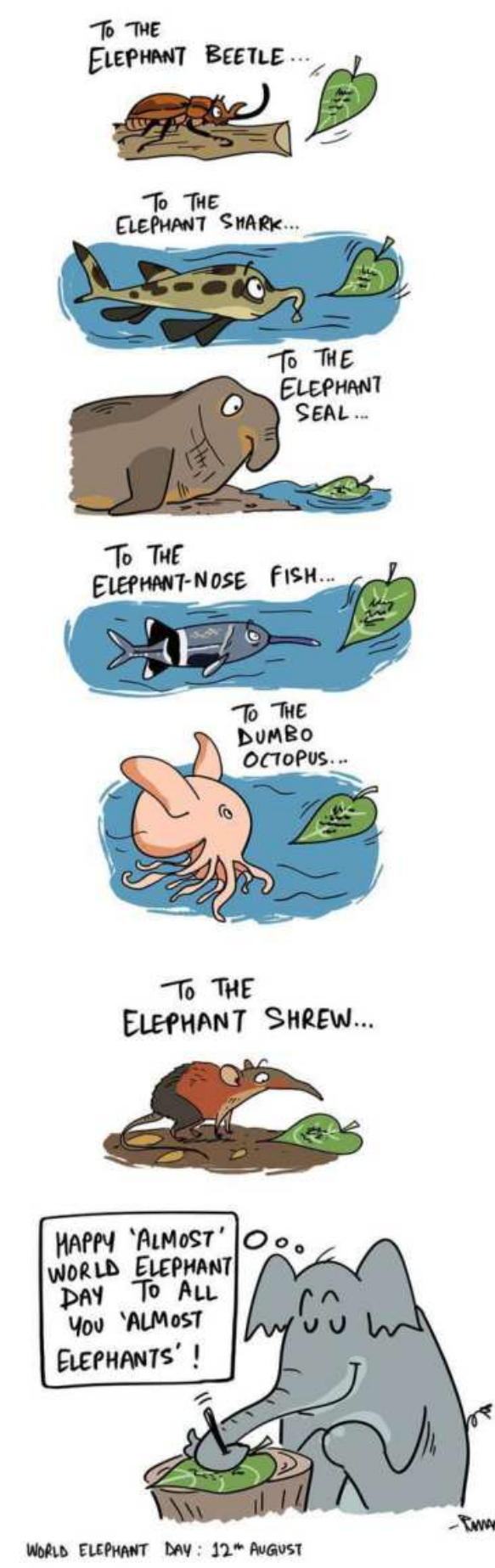
More than gaining a global audience, for Nurboo, the gold medal is a validation of the knowledge, food systems and livelihoods that have enabled communities to survive in one of the world's most toughest landscapes. "If I had sold all my yaks and invested in tippers or JCBs like many others, it would not have been sustainable," he says. For instance, during the pandemic, when tourism and businesses came to a standstill, his family's way of life continued as usual.

"Tourism is seasonal, but this work goes on throughout the year. We need to help young people understand the importance of sustainable livelihoods in Ladakh," says Nurboo. The future of the yak, according to him, is tied not only to cheese, but to the survival of a way of life.

The senior journalist from Ladakh writes on the region's environment, culture and public affairs.

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



IN CONVERSATION

GOING BEYOND RAVI VARMA

Through scattered archives and oral histories, a new book traces the forgotten artists who contributed to Kerala's rich heritage

Manu S. Pillai

When thinking of art in Kerala, the name that usually springs to mind is Raja Ravi Varma. But the region has a richer artistic heritage featuring everything from mural paintings to Deccani miniatures. Sharat Sunder Rajeev, whose first book on the ivory carving tradition of Travancore was published by the Kerala Council for Historical Research, opens up this world of *durbar* painters, female artists, and itinerant European masters in his new book *The Forgotten Atelier* (White Falcon Publishing). Excerpts from an email interview with Rajeev, who teaches at the Department of Architecture & Planning at the College of Engineering, Thiruvananthapuram:

Question: Kerala's greatest art 'export' is Raja Ravi Varma. Your book, however, shows that the earliest painters in his family were women.

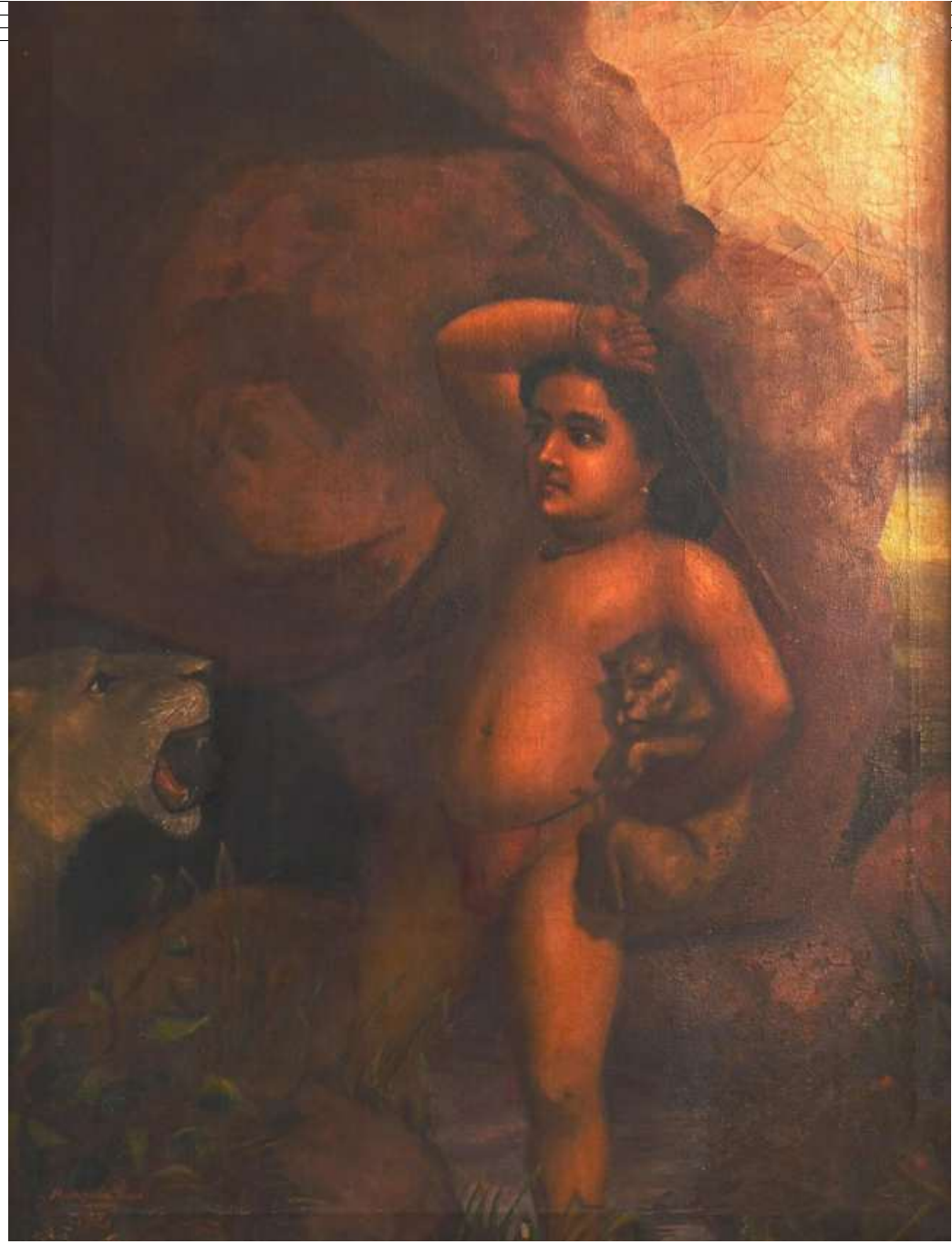
Answer: Yes, the artistic tradition in Ravi Varma's family in Killimanoor began in his

grandmother's generation. Rohininaal Tampuratti and Makammaal Tampuratti are said to have learnt painting from two fugitive princes from British Malabar – a fascinating detail. Ravi Varma's mother and sister were also artists. While social conventions limited their exposure to the wider world, Mangala Bayi, his sister, nevertheless emerged as a talented artist. Today, this legacy continues in Rukmini Varma, Ravi Varma's great-great-granddaughter in Bengaluru.

Q: Ravi Varma was a nobleman. But there was an artist of modest origins at the Travancore *durbar*. Why was Ramaswamy Naidu forgotten?

A: One of the most rewarding aspects of this project was tracing the descendants of these forgotten artists through family archives, oral histories, temple records, and scattered archival references. This made it possible to recover many marginalised figures.

Ramaswamy Naidu was one such artist. He belonged to Madurai's Naidu community, which formed part of the heterogeneous group referred



to as Moomchy painters. He was also among the first Indians to master Western oil painting. Arriving in Travancore in the 1860s, he established himself as one of the court's leading artists. There was even a rivalry between Naidu and Ravi Varma. While Naidu won prizes and had influential patrons, his early death prevented a further ascent. Besides, artists like him left few written records. Many of their works remain unsigned, so histories have typically ignored them.

Q: You also examine the role of European artists.

A: A central argument of *The Forgotten Atelier* is that artistic traditions have never been confined by boundaries. Artists, styles and ideas moved

constantly, shaped by patronage, pilgrimage, trade, politics, even warfare. Art history is a history of movement. The 19th century witnessed unprecedented interactions between Indian courts and European artists. The latter introduced new ideas of realism, perspective, anatomy, portraiture and oil painting. Their works appealed to royalty, offering a new visual language that projected authority and modernity. Interestingly, the earliest reference to a European painting in Kerala dates to the 18th century, when a missionary presented Pope Clement XIV to the Travancore *maharajah*. In the 19th century, Travancore's royals were painted by August Schoefft,



(Clockwise from below) Author Sharat Sunder Rajeev; August Schoefft's painting of the Travancore princes on the cover of Rajeev's book, *The Forgotten Atelier*; *durbar* artist Ramaswamy Naidu's 'Kerala Lady'; and Bharatha by Mangala Bayi. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



F.C. Lewis, and Theodore Jensen. Schoefft is best known for portraits of Sher Singh of Punjab and the last Mughal emperor. In Travancore, he painted Swathi Tirunal, the great icon of Carnatic music. In 1868, Jensen's paintings were displayed in Thiruvananthapuram. This may well have been the first modern art exhibition in Kerala.

Q: Why did these innovations not interact with Kerala's mural painting tradition?

A: Broadly speaking, Kerala's mural tradition flourished in temples and palaces, where its primary function remained religious and ritualistic. The 19th century Western style served a different purpose. So, the two streams evolved along

parallel paths. That said, a few artists did bridge these traditions. For instance, Pulakkat Raman Nair, a celebrated exponent of the Guruvayur School of mural painting. He mastered oil painting while continuing to depict religious themes rooted in Kerala's traditional visual culture.

Q: Besides Ravi Varma, you speak of his wider circle. Who were these artists?

A: One question that has intrigued scholars is the sheer number of paintings attributed to Ravi Varma. He was prolific, and previously unknown works continue to surface. Yet this raises a question: how did a single artist produce such a vast body of work?

While his brother, Raja Raja Varma, was his closest collaborator, he was by no means alone. My research suggests that Ravi Varma's studio functioned like an atelier, where a number of artists assisted the master. These associates included Sekhara Warriar and Madhava Warriar, his first cousins. Another figure was Mukundan Tampi, a relative of Ravi Varma's wife. The book also reconstructs the lives of other neglected figures: Sivarama Pillai, Padmanabhan Tampi, Rama Warriar, Nilakanta Pillai, Ramakrishnan Achari, and N.N. Nampiyar.

Q: How long did your research take? Did you struggle to have it published?

A: *The Forgotten Atelier* took a decade-and-a-half to research. Every inscription, news clipping, or family anecdote became an important piece of the narrative. Publishing an illustrated book is never easy. It appeals to a specialised readership and contains hundreds of images that increase production costs. You need networks or must already be well-known so as to assure publishers a volume of sales. I chose, ultimately, to self-publish. In today's publishing economy, many such illustrated works are in fact self-published. Hopefully, this will change.

Q: Why did these innovations not interact with Kerala's mural painting tradition?

A: Broadly speaking, Kerala's mural tradition flourished in temples and palaces, where its primary function remained religious and ritualistic. The 19th century Western style served a different purpose. So, the two streams evolved along

The interviewer is a historian.



BINGE WATCH

The interview gets weird

From hot wings to mock funerals, celebrity interactions are getting stranger in the hope of becoming more honest

It's not often that you hear a celebrity explicitly plotting their own demise, and the fun only amps up when you hear it from a mad genius like 'Weird Al' Yankovic, the once and future king of parody music. True to form, Yankovic cooks up a two-minute murder movie, involving an encounter with a shark, a gigantic eagle and a covert Nazi organisation. This little chunk of YouTube gold happened during a recent episode of *Grave Conversations*, a uniquely morbid interview show and podcast.

Grave Conversations is hosted by actor David Dastmalchian, known for his scene-stealing cameos in blockbusters (*The Dark Knight*, *Dune*, *The Suicide Squad*) and super-popular TV shows (*Dexter*, *One Piece*).

Peculiar rendezvous In every episode, the host and his guest get into high-end, form-fitted caskets. Safely ensconced in death's sweet embrace, they proceed to riff on mortality, legacy, bucket lists, grief at a loved one's death. Guests so far have included actors Anthony Carrigan,

Jameela Jamil, Kate Siegel, directors Kevin Smith, Mike Flanagan, and astrophysicist-science communicator Neil deGrasse Tyson.

The format and Dastmalchian's inimitable repartee style at once distinguish the show from the dominant run-of-the-mill promotional PR routines. In a recent episode, actor-comedian Riki Lindhome (*Wednesday*, *The Big Bang Theory*) revealed her grandparents ran a funeral home from the family house ("there was literally always a cadaver in the house, and my grandpa would be busy embalming it").

Grave Conversations is just one among many "anti-talk shows" that have sprung up in recent years. These shows employ a central gimmick or surrealist device that functions as a "twist" on the sit-down interview.

Sean Evans' *Hot Ones* is among the pioneers of this technique. In this show, celebrities eat chicken wings with progressively increasing spice levels, until their tear-streaked, blood-red faces

are physically incapable of anything other than straight-up honesty. Brittany Broski's *Royal Court* turns its guests into members of a mock royal court, complete with elaborate costumes and theatrical surroundings. And on *Mythical Kitchen's Last Meals*, chef and host Josh Scherer prepares guests' ideal final meals while talking to them about food, memory, life and death.

Why the gimmicks work

Other than the overall ascent of YouTube itself, the major reason for the sudden mushrooming of such shows is that the celebrity interview had become rather broken. Starting in the late '90s and early 2000s (as online media and social networks gained influence) actors and guests increasingly shut themselves off during interviews, spouting nothing but safe, inane, middle-of-the-road answers.

Every self-respecting actor (or writer, just to be fair) is skilled in the art of producing a lot of words that add up to very little. They were scared of

Bizarre tête-à-tête: Stills from *Grave Conversations*, *Hot Ones*, *Last Meals*, and *Royal Court*.

this new era of instant backlash and continuous public scrutiny, unlike earlier eras when an actor could sit for an interview with a legacy print publication, do the odd TV spot, and leave it at that. So, they over-compensated and gave interviewers almost nothing of substance – hence the rise of shows like *Grave Conversations* and *Hot Ones*, formats that shake things up and break the mould.

Comedy behind conversation

A big influence is avant-garde comedy, or the sort of comedians who would describe their own style as "anti-comedy" or "cringe comedy". Look at Eric André, for example. His style is deliberately confrontational and unpredictable, making guests uncomfortable, pushing them out of their pre-prepared bubbles.

When people laugh at a contemporary podcaster like Bobbi Althoff pretending not to understand her celebrity guests' accents, or feign ignorance of their Grammy-winning albums or Oscar-winning films, they have André's pioneering style to thank. Zach Galifianakis' *Between Two Ferns* is also a big influence on a lot of contemporary deadpan YouTubeers, as is the cringe comedy of Tim Robinson (*I Think You Should Leave*).

At the beginning of the *Grave Conversations* episode with actor Anthony Carrigan, Dastmalchian made the following observation: "We have never been more divided as a species, I feel. And I think it's useful to remind people every now and then that there are still some things that are truly universal, and for me dying is No.1 on that list. It's the Great Unavoidable and I think more adults should be comfortable talking about end-of-life stuff." And to that I say amen, although my acute lifelong claustrophobia means I am not following Dastmalchian's casket lead anytime soon.

Aditya Mani Jha is working on his first book of non-fiction.

Dear readers, the schools are now closed here in London. Which is very convenient. Because now I have to deal with unbearable heat seeping into every pore of my being, but also with unbearable children demanding non-stop entertainment until the schools reopen.

Look readers, make no mistake. I love my children very much. They are wonderful. They are well behaved, they both like reading books, they will eat a wide variety of cuisines, and if I ever tell them to switch off the TV, they will do so immediately, without hesitation, after just 20-35 requests.

Who cannot love children like these?

But, and I am open to your support here, how do you keep children entertained for two months until the schools reopen? Perhaps I am wearing rose-tinted glasses here, but back in my childhood, this was not at all a problem.

If I went to my mother and told her that I was bored and needed entertainment, she would immediately ask me to approach the nearest grandparent and ask them for inputs. My grandparents – bless their souls, may they rest in peace – had two very different approaches to this.

My grandfather would make up entirely fake chores to keep me occupied. For instance, he once asked me to measure the surface area of every wall in my ancestral home so that he could estimate the cost of getting the house painted. Three hours later, after extremely diligent work, I would go back and tell him that the total surface area was something in the range of 17-and-a-half kilograms.



Alice in Wonderland by George Dunlop Leslie. (WIKIMEDIA COMMONS)

Fundemic

He gave me a bar of Five Star chocolate and then informed my mother that she had better start preparing my younger brother for full-time salaried employment because Sidin “seems more of a creative type with a distinct sense of unemployability”.

My grandmother, on the other hand, would make me do actual chores. Go buy vegetables from the shop. See if the chickens have been fed. Check if the milkman has brought milk. The latter ended in tragedy sometime in 1983. She sent me to figure out the milk situation. I found a few bottles of milk. Moved them all to the kitchen for boiling. But then decided to take a swig out

TRICKTIONARY EPISODE 36 KID ME NOT

Are you a child reading this article? Why are you people like this?

of one of the bottles. For the thrills.

Moments later, I was admitted to Sacred Heart Hospital in Pullur, Irinjalakuda, with a form of dysentery that can only be described as explosive.

But now look at my daughter. She comes to me and says: “I would like you to take me to a music performance. And before that, I would like to go to a fancy restaurant for dinner. I have never

Fundemic
/fʌnˈdɛmɪk/
noun
Definition: The relentless, rapidly spreading, and seemingly incurable demand for entertainment that erupts among children the moment schools close for the holidays, characterised by instant amnesia about all fun previously had and an insatiable appetite for the next activity.
Related forms:
Fundemic outbreak (noun): The period between school closing and school reopening.
Fundemically (adverb): In the manner of a fundemic; with complete disregard for all entertainment already provided.
Fundemicist (noun): A child currently in the grip of a fundemic.

been to a fancy restaurant.”

So, I took her. And, like any 12-year-old these days, she ate enough to fill 3-4 full-sized adults. Throughout, we were served by the most amazing waiter. The moment he heard that this was my daughter’s first “fancy restaurant meal”, he pulled out all the stops. He was funny, engaging, entertaining, and made her feel like a total VIP. Immediately, I made a mental note to give the waiter a generous tip for his services.

After the meal, followed by an iced matcha latte, we arrived at the music performance. It was a magnificent two hours of live show. My daughter was enraptured. She did not say a single thing that you expect pre-teen children to say

these days: “I am so tired. This is so boring. How much time is left? Can we go home? Can you please stop making these jokes in public, you are embarrassing me.” Et cetera.

Afterwards, I purchased a few snacks for her, and then we got on a train back home. Twenty minutes into our 30-minute journey, she looked at me.

“Dad?”
“Yes?”

“I am extremely bored. Can we do something interesting when we get home?”

I excused myself, went to the bathroom, and then strangled my water bottle to death. Then I came back and promised her to find something interesting for her to do.

Readers, why are children like this? Are you a child reading this article? Why are you people like this? It makes no sense. Perhaps there should be a word for this situation. And that word is: fundemic.

Example sentence: “Kavitha thought she had cured her daughter’s fundemic by enrolling her in art class, swimming lessons, piano practice, and a robotics workshop, but by Wednesday, the child emerged from her schedule and said ‘Amma, there is literally nothing to do in this house. Are we living in an art film?’”

Friends, have you been the victim of a fundemic? What do I do? Also does anybody want to borrow a 12-year-old and/or a six-year-old for a few weeks? Speedy responses, please.



Sidin Vadukut helps early stage companies communicate better. He blogs at www.whatay.com.

Bob Jones

South’s jump to game was a reasonable decision. He caught a miserable dummy, however, with not much to work with. The opening heart lead went to East’s ace and South won the heart continuation with his king. He cashed the ace of spades, relieved to see the suit splitting 2-1. Still, it looked like he had four

GOREN BRIDGE

Dangerous king North-South vulnerable, South deals

losers. South cashe the king of spades, drawing the last trump, and led a spade to the jack. He ruffed dummy’s last heart back to his hand. There wasn’t much to be done, so South

decided to run the rest of his spades and hope something good would develop. This was the position after all the spades had been cashed: South might have tried

NORTH		
♠ J 9 6 4		
♥ 7 3 2		
♦ J 8 6		
♣ K 9 7		
WEST		EAST
♠ 5		♠ Q 10
♥ J 8 6 5		♥ A Q 9 4
♦ K 7 5 4 3		♦ Q 10 2
♣ A J 8		♣ 10 6 5 3
SOUTH		
♠ A K 8 7 3 2		
♥ K 10		
♦ A 9		
♣ Q 4 2		

The bidding:
SOUTH WEST NORTH EAST
1♠ Pass 2♠ Pass
4♠ All pass

Opening lead: Five of ♥

cashing the ace of diamonds now. He might have caught West napping. Instead, he led a club to dummy’s king and a diamond back to his ace. West was not napping now.

West realised that the king was a dangerous card to keep – he could be end-played with it. He alertly played it under the ace and South had no winning options.

NORTH		
♠ Void		
♥ Void		
♦ J 8 6		
♣ K 9		
WEST		EAST
♠ Void		♠ Void
♥ Void		♥ Void
♦ K 7		♦ Q 10 2
♣ A J 8		♣ 10 6
SOUTH		
♠ Void		
♥ Void		
♦ A 9		
♣ Q 4 2		

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

Women pathbreakers

Berty Ashley

Born on August 9, 1899, P.L. Travers was an Australian-born British writer who created a children’s series centred around a magical nanny. Walt Disney wanted to adapt the books into a film, but Travers was unhappy with many aspects of the adaptation. The film was eventually released in 1964 and won five Academy Awards. Which book and movie was it?

Born on August 9, 1968, Gillian Anderson is an actress and activist best known for playing Dana Scully on an iconic TV show. Scully became a role model, inspiring what became known as the “Scully Effect” where many young women were motivated to take up science as a career. Where did viewers see Scully investigate the unknown?

This scientist discovered a brand-new phenomenon, became the first woman to win a Nobel Prize, was the first female professor at the University of Paris, and became the first person – male or female – to win two Nobel Prizes in different scientific fields. Who was this pioneering figure?

This mathematician is widely regarded as the world’s first computer programmer. Computer pioneer Charles Babbage called her “The Enchantress of Numbers.” Who was this visionary whose name lives on in programming language?



This scientist became the first woman to win a Nobel Prize, and the first person to win two Nobel Prizes in different scientific disciplines. (WIKIMEDIA COMMONS)

Conceived by Mary Shelley when she was 18 years old during a summer holiday, this novel is considered one of the earliest science fiction works. A common misconception is that the titular name refers to the creature rather than the creator. Which novel has inspired countless films and books?

Angela Burdett-Coutts was made a baroness by Queen Victoria for her efforts in building housing for the poor. Among her many initiatives was founding a

home for young women who had been involved in crime. Her co-founder later wrote several books about disadvantaged children and dedicated one of them to her. Who was this famous writer?

This pioneering figure used statistics and data visualisation to transform public health and improve hygiene standards. She also established a professional nursing system and earned the nickname “The Lady with the Lamp” for her night

rounds caring for wounded soldiers. Who was she?

Boudica was the queen of the Iceni tribe who, in 60-61 CE, led a major uprising against Roman rule in Britain. Her forces destroyed several Roman settlements and came close to forcing the emperor to consider withdrawing from Britain. Which Roman emperor, later infamous for the Great Fire of Rome, faced Boudica’s rebellion?

In 1937, this pioneering aviator disappeared over the Pacific while attempting a record-setting flight around the world. After a non-stop 13-hour flight across the Arabian Sea, she continued through India, stopping at Calcutta before resuming her journey. Already famous as the first woman to fly solo across the Atlantic Ocean, who was she?

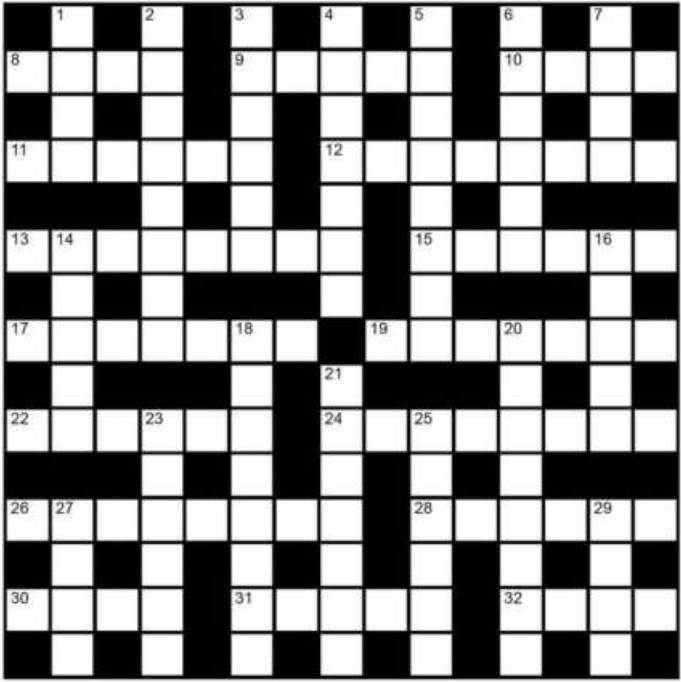
This ruler was the last pharaoh of ancient Egypt and the final monarch of the Ptolemaic Dynasty. By the time she died aged 39, she had ruled Egypt for 21 years and forged two of history’s most famous political alliances. Who was this iconic queen?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called ‘Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion’. @bertyashley

- 1. Mary Poppins
- 2. The X-Files
- 3. Marie Curie
- 4. Ada Lovelace
- 5. Frankenstein
- 6. Charles Dickens
- 7. Florence Nightingale
- 8. Empress Nero
- 9. Amelia Earhart
- 10. Cleopatra

Answers

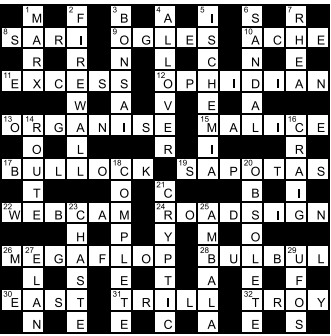
THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 68 (Set by Incognito)



- Across**
8 Deputy’s sin (4)
9 Fixture used to fit carbon lighting device (5)
10 Last word of prayer from soldiers following Arabic at first (4)
11 Kingdom’s submarine releasing SAM at sea (6)
12 Captivates nurse with incantations (8)
13 Alien trooper is after saint (8)
15 Hardy travels around one city (6)
17 Study sessions from Charlie and girls (7)
19 Drug destroyed in Paris (7)
22 Wrongly try before soldier becomes despot (6)
24 Countermand circular letter on volume with reel broadcast about Rugby Union (8)
26 Before time, cattle get cheap accommodation on board (8)
28 Leaving Germany, Goering toured area (6)
30 Silly daughter is at back of boat (4)
31 Part of body in container (not trunk!) (5)
32 Record model animal (4)

- 6 Bird ran back in island (6)
7 Underwear from Galveston (4)
14 Set, perhaps, sounds the same in absence of vision (5)
16 Bore doctor followed by one student after another (5)
18 Bewitch portal (8)
20 I repaired garret containing a bit of inky water (8)
21 Fever about gold is never ending (7)
23 Spies a girl with tangled nets (6)
25 Birds starting to gather in gnarled trees (6)
27 Mate organised sports group (4)
29 Loves police sergeant’s expression admitting mistake (4)

SOLUTION NO. 67



- Down**
1 Brainless librarian may be a fibber (4)
2 Nag babes about things to sit on (8)
3 Silly giant consuming a bit of cake and playing a role (6)
4 Drink manufactured by Irish Republican Army (7)
5 Ghosts’ extraordinary respect after commencement of seance (8)

What the world did not see in Rafael Nadal

His rigid on-field habits were his mental shield, a way to drown out the white noise of pain so his mind could focus entirely on the next ball

N. Anand Venkatesh
anaustram44@gmail.com

The German writer Goethe once wrote a truth that cuts straight to the bone: “Talent is built in calm; character is built in the storm.” Look around today, and you will see a world entirely obsessed with the calm. We are taught to seek comfort, to avoid friction, and to build protective, fragile bubbles around our lives to keep any hint of discomfort away. We treat pain as a stop sign – a signal to quit, pack up, and run. But the Netflix’s documentary series RAFA completely shatters this illusion. It doesn’t just show us a glamorous montage of trophies and roaring crowds, but it introduces us to a man who chose to live, fight, and win from the very centre of a brutal, lifelong storm. For the youth of today, who are so often shielded from hardship, this story is not about tennis. It is a masterclass in how to take the worst life throws at you and use it as fuel to become unstoppable.

To truly understand Rafael Nadal, you have to look at the hidden cracks beneath his greatness. Early in his career, a devastating medical reality threatened to destroy his dream before it even started. He was diagnosed with Müller-Weiss syndrome – a rare, painful, and permanent condition that causes the bone in his foot to literally waste away. The top medical experts gave him a cold, simple choice: undergo surgery, and accept that your career as a professional athlete is over.

At that crossroads, most people would have taken the comfortable exit. Rafa chose the storm. He refused the surgery and his team came up with a temporary, desperate fix which is an extra layer of custom foam stuffed inside his shoe. It was a fragile Band-Aid on a broken body. The extra foam changed how he ran, sending a chain reaction of intense stress up into his knees, his hamstrings, and his back. From that moment on, Nadal was at war with his own body.

His coaches and his family lived in constant anxiety. Year after year, the news behind closed doors was almost always bad. Another tear, another flare-up, another joint giving out. Yet, time and time again, Rafa would look past the medical data, ignore the screaming protests of his nerves, step onto the court, and beat the best players in the world.

This madness reached its peak during his historic run at the French Open. To compete on the brutal clay courts, Nadal did something that defies human logic. He chose to completely numb his foot using constant, aggressive nerve-block injections. Think about the sheer mental toughness required to step



onto a global stage, facing the fiercest competitors on earth, while being entirely unable to feel the foot connecting you to the ground. He was running on pure muscle memory, instinct, and an iron will. He was surviving on painkillers, yet he marched through the tournament to lift the championship trophy.

The world often looked at Nadal’s rigid on-court habits in the way he perfectly aligned his water bottles, swept the baseline, or fixed his clothes before every single serve and laughed, calling it superstition. But the truth is much deeper. When your physical body is burning in agony, strict routine is how you take control back from the chaos. Those habits were his mental shield, a way to drown out the white noise of pain so his mind could focus entirely on the next ball.

There is a dangerous lie being fed to the next generation: that a successful life is supposed to be an easy, painless one. We celebrate the finish line but completely erase the bloody footprints it took to get there. Young people see a champion holding a golden trophy under a shower of confetti, completely blind to the hundreds of hours that same champion spent crying on a treatment table, surrounded by a

worried family and an anxious team. We must show youngsters this story to teach them that pain is not a dead end. It can be a massive spark. Nadal proved that suffering does not have to break you and that it can reveal exactly what you are made of. He showed the world that when you stop running from discomfort, you take away its power over you. Eventually, as it does to everyone, time delivered its final verdict. The body could simply take no more, the foam insoles and nerve blocks could no longer bridge the gap, and he had to retire. But Rafael Nadal did not leave the sport because he was broken but he left because he had completely emptied the tank. He left every single ounce of his humanity on the court. If we want to build a generation capable of surviving hard times and achieving true greatness, we have to teach them to stop hiding in the calm. True character is only built when you have the courage to look directly into the eyes of the storm, smile through the pain, and refuse to back down.

N. Anand Venkatesh is a judge of the Madras High Court

The shrill roads of Delhi

Sunanda Bharti
sunanda.bharti@gmail.com

Perhaps it is time to remove the words “Horn Please” or “Blow Horn” from the back of trucks and other vehicles. What may once have been a practical instruction now appears to function as a psychological trigger.

The typical Delhi driver approaches the horn with the enthusiasm of a pianist discovering a new keyboard.

So, the average Delhi motorist does not need encouragement to honk, but something opposite.

There are, broadly speaking, three kinds of drivers on Delhi’s roads. The first drives a vehicle with no brakes, putting any bullet train to shame. The second drives a vehicle with no accelerator, making a buffalo cart look positively dynamic.

The third, and by far the most fascinating species, drives a vehicle powered almost entirely by the horn.

This has led me to a policy proposal. Motor manufacturers should begin installing horns with an expiry limit. Every vehicle may be entitled to a thousand complimentary honks. Thereafter, the horn ceases to function until it is recharged.

The first recharge may be reasonably priced.

Every subsequent recharge should attract a premium. A portion of the proceeds could be dedicated to combating noise pollution in the capital.

Sharada A.L.
alsharada518@gmail.com

A friend recently forgot her phone at home. She wanted to call her family but could not because she did not remember a single phone number. For a while, she felt completely stranded. She had forgotten how to reach them, having quietly delegated that memory to the phone she had left behind.

That incident stayed with me because my own memory behaves very differently.

I remember phone numbers with surprising ease. Not because I have an exceptional memory, but because I look for patterns. Many numbers begin with familiar combinations. The remaining digits often have a rhythm of their own. Once I discover that rhythm, the number stays with me.

A language of its own It made me realise that memory has a language of its own. It loves rhythm, pattern, and association. We remember songs because of their melody, poems because of their rhythm, stories because one event leads naturally to another. Even a phone

Memory in the pocket

When the brain knows information can be had from a device, it makes less effort to remember



GETTY IMAGES/ ISTOCK

number becomes memorable when it stops being a random string of digits and begins to make sense.

Names, however, are another matter.

More than once, I have been talking to a close friend and have suddenly forgotten her husband or children’s names. Once, I asked, “How are the kids?” She replied that they were doing well. Normally, I would have asked about each child individually. Instead, the conversation stopped there because I could not remember their names.

Finally, I admitted it. We laughed. But I came away with an uncomfortable thought.

It wasn’t just embarrassing. It restricted the conversation. I realised that forgetting

names does not merely mean losing information. It means losing the ability to make conversations personal and meaningful. When I address people by their names, they know I remember them. When I remember a story they shared months ago, they know I was listening. Memory is a language of relationships, not simply a storage device.

For years, I assumed these lapses were simply a part of growing older. Then I realised it wasn’t just me.

I see young people interrupting conversations to search for facts they probably know. Colleagues looking up phone numbers they have dialled for years. Children depending on GPS to find places they visit regularly. They forget names and

details as much as I do. Perhaps this isn’t about age at all.

A little browsing revealed that researchers call this the Google effect or digital amnesia. When we know information can be retrieved instantly from a device, our brains make less effort to remember it. Gradually, we become better at remembering where information is stored than the information itself.

I am not suggesting that technology is the villain. Far from it. My phone has made life easier in countless ways. But somewhere along the way, it has quietly become an extension of my memory.

That made me ask myself a simple question. Are there some memories I should never outsource? For me, the answer is yes.

The phone numbers of the people I love. The names of people who matter. The birthdays of dear ones. The route to a friend’s house. A few poems, songs and prayers that have become a part of me. The stories that bind me to family and friends. Not because my phone cannot remember them. But because I need to remember them to reach out and relate to the people who matter to me, without the mediation of a device.

openpage 07

articles and letters from readers

FEEDBACK

Letters to the Magazine can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

The revival of handwritten letters shows that meaningful communication still matters. (‘The quiet appeal of snail mail’; Aug. 2) Schools and libraries can encourage letter-writing clubs to improve expression, creativity and emotional well-being while reminding young people that not every valuable experience needs a screen.

Prajesh Paramasivan

It would be unfortunate if handwriting, once valued for its low cost and human warmth, were gradually transformed into a luxury hobby associated only with collectors, enthusiasts or the affluent. The effort to preserve handwritten culture should therefore focus not merely on celebrating its aesthetic charm, but also on protecting its accessibility for ordinary people who continue to use it as an essential means of communication.

S. Sundareswara Pandiyan

Develop reading habit

Stories exploring family relationships and personal struggles often help readers understand society better. (‘The sins of fathers’; Aug. 2) Good literature encourages empathy. Schools, colleges and public libraries should actively promote reading through book discussions and literary events so that thoughtful writing reaches a wider generation of readers.

S. Durga Arunkumar

Evolving dialogues

Critical discussion of cinema should evolve with changing social realities. (‘Ways of seeing and not seeing’; Aug. 2)



MORE ON THE WEB

www.thehindu.com/opinion/open-page

The great Indian lie

Ask anyone why he is late, the answer will be, “I am reaching in five minutes.”

Jeter Dagam

Tryst with libraries

In love with hallowed spaces occupied by book shelves

Murali M. Mallareddy

Enjoying theatre

What unfolds on stage is live, fragile, and unrepeatable

Rajani Balaji

Vegetable seller and maths wizard

Speed of her calculations puts to shame those who use calculators to do the sum

Vijayalakshmi Kadambari

Contributions of up to a length of 700 words may be e-mailed to: openpage@thehindu.co.in Please provide the postal address and a brief background of the writer. The mail must certify that it is original writing, exclusive to this page. The Hindu views plagiarism as a serious offence. Given the large volume of submissions, we regret that we are unable to acknowledge receipt or entertain queries about submissions. If a piece is not published for eight weeks please consider that it is not being used. The publication of a piece on this page is not to be considered an endorsement by The Hindu of the views contained therein.

(Clockwise from below) Panels from *Vyasa: The Beginning* by Sankha Banerjee; *Comixense*; the exhibits at MAP; and a visitor listening to audio stories on *Amar Chitra Katha*'s vinyls. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



Menaka Raman

As a child, long before I was enamoured by the likes of *Nancy Drew*, *The Hardy Boys* and *Sweet Valley High*, I existed on a steady diet of *Archie* comics. My 'Double Digests' binge was only interrupted when the latest issue of *Target* magazine arrived at home. I would always seek out the Gardhab Das and Detective Moomchala comics first, before turning my attention to the issue's many other delights.

Back then, I had little understanding of comics beyond the knowledge that the small squares provided a sharp and fleeting pleasure. As I grew up, the idea that comics were not serious reading was drilled into my head and I was forced to move on to other literary pastures. What an absolute shame.

Walking through the impeccably curated *A Moving Line: 1,500 Years of Indian Visual Storytelling*, a new exhibition at the Museum of Art and Photography (MAP) in Bengaluru, I am struck by how much I have missed out on. Curated by the painter and graphic novelist Amruta Patil, the exhibition traces India's journey in visual storytelling across 15 centuries.

Homegrown comics scene

The idea for the exhibition took root when Patil was in Angoulême, France, a city that has been hosting an international comics festival for over 50 years. "You should do something about the Indian comics scene," she said to a friend working at the comics museum there. His response, she says, was unsurprising: "There's an Indian comics scene?"

The exhibition is proof that such a thing does indeed exist. More than 250 works are on display – ranging from temple friezes to print comics,



Traditional inflections in our visual storytelling include a maximalist aesthetic and bias towards bold lines and vibrant palettes. In terms of storylines, we have always loved multiple story tracks running parallel, 'nested' stories, the presence of a *sutradhar* [oral storyteller]

AMRUTA PATIL
Curator, painter and graphic novelist

graphic novels, Instagram cartoons and more – giving visitors a chance to trace Indian comic creation.

Spread across two exhibition halls, it is artfully designed with the first space presenting a more chronological overview, while the second groups work thematically. Central spaces also allow visitors to sit down and browse comic books and anthologies in which some exhibits were originally published, and a special publication that

BEFORE MANGA, INDIA HAD MURALS

A new exhibition at MAP explores 1,500 years of the country's visual storytelling, making its way from temple carvings to *Amar Chitra Katha* and *Comixense*

explores themes reflected in the show. "It includes an introduction by Amruta, followed by nine essays and 11 graphic narratives," says Khushi Bansal, a curator with MAP and co-editor of the publication.

'A boggling diversity of styles'

Upon entering the space, one is met by a hero stone, a temple frieze from the city's Someshwara temple depicting the wedding of Shiva and Parvati, and a painting of Hanuman meeting Sita in Ashok Vatika garden. Each shows how, long before the word comic even existed, the art of telling stories sequentially has existed in India.

Beside a *kaavad*, a portable painted shrine with panels that itinerant storytellers unfolded as they

narrate their tales, sits *pattachitra* scrolls that unspool myths in ochre and vermilion. These give way to a wall covered with *Amar Chitra Katha* (ACK) covers, including one of Shivaji, Mirabai and stories from the *Panchatantra*. Alongside, a cluster of ACK vinyls play audio stories.

Sitting comfortably alongside *Phantom*, *Tin Tin* and *Captain Vyom* comics, is a space dedicated to colonial India's burgeoning comics scene, steeped in satire. Bengal dominates this space, from *Basantak* to the contributions of the Tagore and Ray family. I would, however, have loved to know more about Sukhalata Rao, Satyajit Ray's aunt and, by most accounts, India's first female cartoonist. It's a footnote that feels like it deserves its own show.



Patil says she intentionally clustered unexpected work together – comics that feature the adventures of Amitabh Bachchan beside a futuristic panel from Bishakh Som's *Apsara Engine*, a miniature painting of Sita next to Orijit Sen's work based on the *Hamza Nama*. "This way, you get a sense of the boggling diversity of styles, themes, and nuanced points of view," she says.

A local idiom

Personally, as a children's book author, it was wonderful to see how artists such as Priya Kuriyan, Parismita Singh, Lokesh Khodke, Rajiv Eipe, and Soumya Menon, whose work I'm familiar with in the creation of picture books, have tackled themes of gender, migration, climate, caste and Indian life outside of children's publishing.

But what will young comic-book readers who inhale manga make of the exhibit? "It is rare that young Indians who consume homogenised narratives from the Global North get to see alternatives: intelligent writing and original visual styles that emerged out of an Indian idiom," Patil says, adding that she hopes all visitors will approach the

displays with curiosity and an open mind.

The exhibition certainly opened my eyes to the breadth of narratives and styles that exist in the Indian comics scene, which has picked up momentum in recent years – from *Comixense*, Orijit Sen's quarterly for teenagers and young adults, to the Indie Comix Fest, run by and for self-published creators, and even Westland's recent announcement of Lattis, a new imprint for comic adaptations of classic Indian stories.

Awareness levels about India's visual storytelling legacy certainly needs bolstering, something that is difficult Patil says, given how much has been lost to lapsed print runs, language silos and unimaginative custodians. Add to this, the lack of archives, and one sees the exhibition in a new light. It is a labour of love. And one can only hope that those who come, leave having fallen a little bit more in love with Indian comics.

A Moving Line is on show till November 15 at MAP, Bengaluru.

The writer is a children's book author and columnist based in Bengaluru.

Rajni George

Many of my paintings feature solitary figures looking at vast landscapes, reflecting on change and uncertainty," says 41-year-old Kashmiri artist Azim Hassan. "I try to paint erasure. I try to paint such emotional realities."

Time spent in Hangzhou, and now in Foshan in nearby Guangdong province, China, has given him a more nuanced perspective on his native Anantnag. Its panoramic landscapes are now patrolled by soldiers, and older buildings are gradually giving way to trendy restaurants, yet parts of the region seem suspended in time.

When I visit the Valley over the summer, I find myself seeing its dreamy meadows, water-filled vistas and sombre protagonists through Hassan's eyes. His body of work – over 200 paintings, exhibited in solo and group exhibitions across India, China, South Korea, Pakistan, Portugal and the United States – is the starting point for a long virtual conversation.

An earnest young man with a pensive demeanour, Hassan left home for the first time in 2010. The influence of those formative years is evident in every facet of his work. We discuss the *dubb*, the old-fashioned wooden balcony that features in his painting, *The Dubb and the Nab*, but which is no longer seen in the palatial American classical-style houses that are now coming up across the



Dreaming of the Valley

This Kashmiri artist creates stunning portraits of home from a studio in China

Valley. These architectural details remain integral to Hassan's 'dream-like, sublime landscape' (*nab* means sky in Kashmiri).

Creating art away from one's homeland offers both restrictions and freedoms, making reinvention – and the

emergence of a new visual idiom – possible. *The Dubb and the Nab*, for instance, brings together the region's diverse communities in an otherworldly marketplace scene. "The main characters in this painting are the Bakarwals, a nomadic pastoral

Azim Hassan in his studio in Foshan, China; and (below) his paintings. (COURTESY THE ARTIST)



The interiority of pathos – an old man losing his eyesight while weaving a shawl – finds an echo in his vivid imagery, wherein recurring clouds carry considerable emotional weight.

Like the American painter Edward Hopper, whose work explored urban loneliness, Hassan is preoccupied with the interplay of light and shadow. "I'm fascinated by chiaroscuro [a technique that uses strong, bold contrasts between light and dark]. In the Baroque period, they used it to create drama and intensity through contrast," he says.

Over time, a pervasive blue has steeped into many of his canvases, becoming an integral part of his visual language. "It is connected to spirituality, melancholy, silence, and stillness," he explains. "Kashmir has always felt like a deeply spiritual and mystical place."

Of blue and chiaroscuro

Hassan describes the works in his first solo exhibition, *Four Shadows* (2021), as a "confrontation between beauty and hardship, vulnerability and resilience."

Hassan admires the work of Kashmiri artists such as Shafi Chaman and graphic novelist Malik Sajad, although he does not consider himself stylistically influenced by any artists from the region. As a struggling art student pursuing a Master's degree at Jamia Millia Islamia in Delhi, he covered his expenses through commissioned illustrations and received support from benefactors such as Nighat Shafi, who runs an NGO in Srinagar and funded his studies while he was at Kashmir University. A competitive scholarship to the China Academy of Art in Hangzhou further honed his technical skills.

Today, Hassan teaches IB (International Baccalaureate) art in China, a steady job that has enabled him to contribute to Shafi's NGO. Although he briefly tried living in Anantnag again, he ultimately returned to China and recently married a woman from Zhejiang province.

Legacy of conflict

Growing up, newspapers often arrived at Hassan's home several days late. "I haven't understood the conflict in its entirety, but I've always felt it in everyday life," he says. "As a painter, I'm equally drawn to another side of Kashmir – the landscapes, the beauty, and the cultural traditions I grew up with. Many of those traditions and memories are slowly fading away."

Yet, the conflict in Kashmir forms an inescapable backdrop, shaping decades of unrest – and some of Hassan's

most evocative paintings. His 'Boy by the Window' responds to the seven months of violence and curfew that engulfed the Valley in 2016. The painting's haunting image of a boy and his blinded cat bears the unmistakable marks of violence, yet also suggests a fragile moment of temporary peace, in repose. In 'Beyond the Broken', the same boy stands before a window, with a candle.

"Life could be challenging growing up," says Hassan. His parents were not a part of his artistic journey, yet, raised by his maternal uncle, who encouraged his vocation, he grew up in a loving, liberal family steeped in the arts.

In Anantnag, I visit his uncle's farm and the house where Hassan lived as a child, spending time with his three charismatic younger cousin brothers.

Seated in the family kitchen, we sip pink, salty *nun chai* and eat traditional Kashmiri bread, cross-legged on the floor before the *dastarkhan*, the cloth laid out for meals. Kittens dart about outside.

This is the life Hassan may never fully return to: one that gathers his family within its warmth, even as it may limit the opportunities available to these young men beyond Kashmir. They look up to their older brother, who left home in order to show it to the world, in all its beautiful complexity.

The writer-editor is based in South India.